PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Colfax Massacre — A House Divided

One Day, and the Ruling That Followed

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Colfax Massacre — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Weigh what the event and the court case prove — and how far their consequences reached

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1874 — "Worse than Slavery"



"The Union As It Was — The Lost Cause, Worse Than Slavery" — wood engraving by Thomas Nast, Harper's Weekly, 1874, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · UNITED STATES V. CRUIKSHANK · 1876 — What the Court ruled

> *The Supreme Court overturned the convictions of Colfax attackers, holding that the Fourteenth Amendment restrained only state action, not the acts of private individuals — so protecting citizens from private mob violence was a matter for the states, not the federal government.*
> *— summary of United States v. Cruikshank (1876). Public domain*

— summary of United States v. Cruikshank (1876). Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · WHAT HAPPENED

In your own words, describe what happened at Colfax on Easter 1873, and why it is remembered as the bloodiest single day of Reconstruction.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE RULING'S LOGIC

Why did the Cruikshank ruling make it so much harder for the federal government to protect Black citizens?

- ☐ A. it left protection from private mobs to the states, which were falling under white Democratic control
- ☐ B. it freed the enslaved
- ☐ C. it strengthened federal power
- ☐ D. it had no real effect

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · EVENT + RULING

Explain how the massacre and the court ruling worked together to damage Reconstruction. Why is a Supreme Court decision sometimes as powerful as an army?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · SIGNIFICANCE

In three or four sentences, judge the historical significance of Colfax and Cruikshank. How did they help shape what came next — Redemption and Jim Crow?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Colfax Massacre — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "At Colfax…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — A. it left protection from private mobs to the states, which were falling under white Democratic control**

Right. By saying the 14th Amendment only limited states — not private mobs — the Court left protection from terror up to the states, which were themselves being captured by white Democrats.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The massacre showed…; the ruling then…; together they…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Colfax and Cruikshank were significant because…"